DIALECTICS: Walking the Middle Path SESSION 9

Dialectics- How to Think/Act Dialectically
Balancing Acceptance and Change
Finding the Synthesis Between Opposites

Overview:
Walking the Middle Path

Balancing Acceptance and Change

DIALECTICS

Balancing opposites while entering the paradox of "yes" and "no," "true" and "not true," at the very same time.

VALIDATION

Including the valid and understandable in ourselves

RECOVERING FROM INVALIDATION

From a nondefensive position, find the valid, acknowledge the invalid, and radically accept yourself.

STRATEGIES FOR CHANGING BEHAVIOR

Use behavioral principles to increase desired behaviors

Dialectics

DIALECTICS REMINDS US THAT

1. **The universe is filled with opposing sides/opposing forces.**

   There is always more than one way to see a situation, and more than one way to solve a problem.

   Two things that seem like opposites can both be true.

2. **Everything and every person is connected in some way.**

   The waves and the ocean are one.

   The slightest move of the butterfly affects the furthest star.

3. **Change is the only constant.**

   Meaning and truth evolve over time.

   Each moment is new; reality itself changes with each moment.

4. **Change is transactional.**

   What we do influences our environment and other people in it.

   The environment and other people influence us.

How to Think and Act Dialectically

1. There is always more than one side to anything that exists. Look for both sides.

- ☐ **Ask Wise Mind: What am I missing?** Where is the kernel of truth in the other side?
- ☐ **Let go of extremes:** Change "either-or" to "both-and," "always" or "never" to "sometimes."
- ☐ **Balance opposites:** Validate both sides when you disagree, accept reality, and work to change.
- ☐ **Make lemonade out of lemons.**
- ☐ **Embrace confusion:** Enter the paradox of yes and no, or true and not true.
- ☐ **Play devil's advocate:** Argue each side of your own position with equal passion. **Use metaphors and storytelling** to unstick and free the mind.
- ☐ Other ways to see all sides of a situation: _____

2. Be aware that you are connected.

- ☐ **Treat others as you want them to treat you.**
- ☐ **Look for similarities among people instead of differences.**
- ☐ **Notice the physical connections** among all things.
- ☐ Other ways to stay aware of connections: _____

3. Embrace change.

- ☐ **Throw yourself into change:** Allow it. Embrace it.
- ☐ **Practice radical acceptance of change** when rules, circumstances, people, and relationships change in ways you don't like.
- ☐ **Practice getting used to change:** Make small changes to practice this (e.g., purposely change where you sit, who you talk with, what route you take when going to a familiar place).
- ☐ Other ways to embrace change: _____

4. Change is transactional: Remember that you affect your environment and your environment affects you.

- ☐ **Pay attention to your effect on others** and how they affect you.
- ☐ **Practice letting go of blame** by looking for how your own and others' behaviors are caused by many interactions over time.
- ☐ **Remind yourself that all things, including all behaviors, are caused.**
- ☐ Other ways to see transactions: _____

Note. Adapted from Miller, A. L., Rathus, J. H., & Linehan, M. M. (2007). *Dialectical behavior therapy with suicidal adolescents.* New York: Guilford Press. Copyright 2007 by The Guilford Press. Adapted by permission.

Walking the Middle Path: Finding the Synthesis between Opposites

Reasonable mind ⟷ **Emotion mind**

Both regulate actions and make decisions based on reason,
And
take into account values and experience even strong emotions as they come and go.

Doing mind ⟷ **Nothing-to-do mind**

Both do what is needed in the moment (including reviewing the past or planning for the future),
And
experience fully the uniqueness of each moment in the moment.

Intense desire for change of the moment ⟷ **Radical acceptance of the moment**

Both allow yourself to have an intense desire to have something else than what is now,
And
be willing to radically accept what you have in your life in the present moment.

Self-denial ⟷ **Self-indulgence**

Both practice moderation,
And
satisfy the senses.

Other:

_____ ⟷ _____

_____ ⟷ _____

Dialectics Checklist

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Everyday dialectical practice: Check off dialectical practice exercises each time you do one. For each skill you practice, give it a rating to indicate how effective that skill was in helping you reach your personal and interpersonal goals. Rate from a low of 1 (not at all effective) to a high of 5 (very effective).

Rating (1–5)

Looked at both sides:

❑❑❑❑ 1. Asked Wise Mind: "What am I missing?" ____

❑❑❑❑ 2. Looked for the kernel of truth in another person's side. ____

❑❑❑❑ 3. Stayed away from extremes (such as "always" or never"), and instead thought or said: _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 4. Balanced opposites in my life: ❑ Validated both myself and a person I disagreed with ❑ Accepted reality and tried to change it ❑ Stayed attached and also let go ❑ Other (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 5. Made lemonade out of lemons (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 6. Embraced confusion (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 7. Played devil's advocate by arguing both my side and also the other side (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 8. Used a metaphor or story to describe my own point of view (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 9. Did 3-minute Wise Mind to slow down "doing mind" in my everyday life. ____

❑❑❑❑ 10. Other (describe): _____ ____

Stayed aware of my connection:

❑❑❑❑ 11. Treated others as I want to be treated (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 12. Looked for similarities between myself and others (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 13. Noticed the physical connections between all things (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 14. Other (describe): _____ ____

Embraced change:

❑❑❑❑ 15. Practiced radical acceptance of change (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 16. Purposely made changes in small ways to get used to change (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 17. Other (describe): _____ ____

Remembered that change is transactional:

❑❑❑❑ 18. Paid attention to my effect on others (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 19. Paid attention to effect of others on me (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 20. Practiced letting go of blame (describe): _____ ____

❑❑❑❑ 21. Reminded myself that all things, including all behaviors, are caused ____

❑❑❑❑ 22. Other (describe): _____ ____

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Examples of Opposite Sides That Can Both Be True

- ❑ 1. You can want to change and be doing the best you can, AND still need to do better, try harder, and be more motivated to change.
- ❑ 2. You are tough AND you are gentle.
- ❑ 3. You can be independent AND also want help. (You can allow somebody else to be independent AND also give them help.)
- ❑ 4. You can want to be alone AND also want to be connected to others.
- ❑ 5. You can share some things with others AND also keep some things private.
- ❑ 6. You can be by yourself AND still be connected to others.
- ❑ 7. You can be with others AND be lonely.
- ❑ 8. You can be a misfit in one group AND fit in perfectly in another group. (A tulip in a rose garden can also be a tulip in a tulip garden.)
- ❑ 9. You can accept yourself the way you are AND still want to change. (You can accept others as they are AND still want them to change.)
- ❑ 10. At times you need to both control AND tolerate your emotions.
- ❑ 11. You may have a valid reason for believing what you believe, AND you may still be wrong or incorrect.
- ❑ 12. Someone may have valid reasons for wanting something from you, AND you may have valid reasons for saying no.
- ❑ 13. The day can be sunny, AND it can rain.
- ❑ 14. You can be mad at somebody AND also love and respect the person.
- ❑ 15. (You can be mad at yourself AND also love and respect yourself.)
- ❑ 16. You can have a disagreement with somebody AND also be friends.
- ❑ 17. You can disagree with the rules AND also follow the rules.
- ❑ 18. You can understand why somebody is feeling or behaving in a certain way, AND also disagree with his or her behavior and ask that it be changed.
- ❑ 19. Others: _____

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